

The Secret Superpower of World Cup Songs (It's Not Just Soccer!)

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Have you ever heard a song so exciting it made you want to jump up and dance even if you weren't watching a game? That's the magic of World Cup songs! These aren't just background music; they're like a giant, global high-five. Some have even changed people's lives. Take Shakira's 'Waka Waka (This Time for Africa)' from 2010. It mixed African and Colombian beats and was absolutely everywhere. You couldn't escape it and honestly, nobody wanted to! It became the most streamed World Cup song ever and even earned a **Guinness World Record**. But here's the coolest part: while making the video, Shakira met a soccer player named Gerard Piqué. They later had two kids! 'It turned me into my mother,' she said. How wild is that? But the story of World Cup music starts way earlier. Back in 1962, a Chilean rock band called Los Ramblers made a peppy song to cheer for their team. FIFA didn't even ask them to! It became a huge hit, and that's when the big bosses realized: people love a sports **soundtrack**. Since then, we've gotten all kinds of **bops**. In 2006, **opera** singers Il Divo and R&B star Toni Braxton made a beautiful **ballad** about 'the glory and the pain' of the game. In 2014, Pitbull and Jennifer Lopez gave us a club banger that felt more like a dance party than a soccer match. And in 2022, 'Hayya Hayya' (which means 'let's go' in Arabic) blended Afrobeats and Middle Eastern sounds with singers from America, Nigeria, and Qatar. Each song is a little time capsule of sound and joy. So as the 2026 games kick off, maybe give these **anthems** a listen. You might just find your new favorite pump-up jam!

Word Treasure

anthems -- Songs that are meant to be grand and uplifting, often used for celebrations or big events.

Guinness World Record -- A famous book that keeps track of amazing things, like the most streamed song or the tallest person.

soundtrack -- A collection of music that goes along with a movie, show, or event.

bops -- Catchy, lively songs that make you want to dance.

ballad -- A slow, emotional song, often about love or sad feelings.

opera -- A style of music where singers use very strong, trained voices, often in big theaters.

Background you need

The FIFA World Cup is the biggest soccer tournament in the world, held every four years by an organization called FIFA.

The first famous World Cup song was made by a band in Chile in 1962, and since then, official and unofficial songs have hyped up fans.

The 2026 World Cup will take place in the United States, Canada, and Mexico, so new anthems are on the way.

Break it down

WHO: Singers and bands like Shakira, the Chilean rock group Los Ramblers, Il Divo, Toni Braxton, Pitbull, and Jennifer Lopez.

WHAT: World Cup songs are more than just background music; they became global anthems and a 'time capsule of sound and joy.'

WHERE: At World Cup tournaments across the globe, from 1962 until the upcoming 2026 event.

WHY: Because people love the excitement of sports and dancing, and these catchy tunes connect fans everywhere.

Why it matters

Even if you don't play soccer, a powerful song can make you feel connected to a worldwide celebration, just like when your school's favorite song brings everyone together.

Test what you remember

1. What special honor did Shakira's 'Waka Waka' earn?
 - (A) An Olympic medal
 - (B) A Grammy Award
 - (C) A Guinness World Record
 - (D) A Nobel Peace Prize
2. Which band made a peppy song for the 1962 World Cup without FIFA asking?
 - (A) Los Ramblers
 - (B) Il Divo
 - (C) The Beatles
 - (D) Pitbull's band
3. Who sang a ballad about the glory and pain of soccer in 2006?
 - (A) Pitbull and J.Lo
 - (B) Shakira
 - (C) Il Divo and Toni Braxton
 - (D) Los Ramblers
4. What does the Arabic phrase 'Hayya Hayya' mean in English?
 - (A) Go team
 - (B) Let's go
 - (C) Score a goal
 - (D) World Cup
5. Which World Cup song did Pitbull and Jennifer Lopez perform?
 - (A) Waka Waka
 - (B) Hayya Hayya
 - (C) The 2014 club banger
 - (D) A ballad
6. What surprising thing happened to Shakira while making the 'Waka Waka' video?
 - (A) She learned to play soccer
 - (B) She met her future partner Gerard Piqué
 - (C) She forgot the lyrics
 - (D) She broke her leg

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Fan excitement:** These songs get everyone pumped up for the matches and become memories of fun times with friends.
2. **Artist pride:** Singers and bands get a chance to share their culture with the whole world, like Shakira mixing Colombian and African beats.
3. **Skeptical view:** Some people think these songs are just clever advertisements for the World Cup, made to sell records and not really about soccer.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):